

TALKING SHOP

Armed with a city map, strong determination and a knack for threading through swarms of people, you make your way along the streets of Chandni Chowk, looking for that sari shop your friend couldn't stop raving about. There's an easier way to make it there: just fish out your cellphone and punch in Just Dial's national number 6999-9999. Not only will a pleasant voice get you out of the maze, but its soon-to-be-added call-connect feature will hook you up directly to the sari shop if you are still lost.

All his life Venkatachalam Sthanu Subra Mani, founder and managing director, Just Dial, envisaged a network that made the conventional Yellow Pages available at a click—on the phone, via sms and the Internet. It all begun in 1996 with Rs 50,000, one 8888888 telephone number, rented furniture, pcs, and a 300 sq ft garage. "Capital is important, but envisioning creative ways to do business brings success closer," says Mani, who began with four employees and now heads 3,500 employees across 240 cities.

**TECHNICAL
GLITCHES AND
LACK OF TELEPHONE
CONNECTIONS
COULD NOT
OBSTRUCT JUST
DIAL'S AIM OF
BEING MUCH
MORE THAN JUST
A DIRECTORY
SERVICE ON
THE PHONE.**

Panning back to the '80s when the Internet, cellphones or even a computer were considered privileges, he can afford to sound satisfied. "I was pursuing my graduation by correspondence and a CA simultaneously," says Mumbai-based Mani, who wasn't able to complete his professional education due to financial reasons and had to take up a sales job with United Database India, the first to bring out Yellow Pages in liaison with MTNL in 1987. Within two years, he was churning out ideas. But a

personal financial crisis didn't let him grow until 1989, when he started a company with his partner, who brought in the funds. "We were thinking much ahead of the times," explains Mani, as the telecom industry hadn't opened up and there were about four lakh connections in Mumbai in 1989, as opposed to four million today. The company became more than just a directory service on the phone. "You could find anything under the sun—product, service, in any city or location. Later I was told such a service wasn't found anywhere in the world. We felt like pioneers," he adds. But the ride was bumpy with lack of telephone connections and technical drawbacks. And due to the instability of the government, Mani handed over his shares after two years and called it quits. It was this ending that set in motion the philosophy be-



MANDAR DEODHAR